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**While women
make up 34%
of entry-
level roles
in India's
tech sector,
the number
plummets
to 13% at
managerial
levels**

EMPOWERING WOMEN, POWERING TECH

To realise the vision of **Viksit Bharat**, we must ensure that India's workforce is not only future-ready but also equitably led

► **AS INDIA MARCHES** towards its centennial in 2047, poised to become the world's third-largest economy and a digital-first powerhouse, there's one truth we cannot afford to ignore: our future will not just be defined by the technology we build, but also by who builds it. And increasingly, that answer must be women.

According to Nasscom, over two million women are already employed in India's tech sector, making up nearly 36% of the total tech workforce, one of the highest in the world. Women are building artificial intelligence (AI) systems, shaping public platforms, founding deep-tech start-ups, and leading digital public infrastructure. But the true inflection point will not be when women are participating. It will be when they are leading. This isn't just a matter of representation. It's a matter of national competitiveness, inclusive innovation, and economic resilience.

RETURNSHIPS

Across India, thousands of experienced women have paused, not because of a lack of

talent, but because the industry hasn't designed a way back. A career break, often for caregiving, leads to outdated skills, lost networks, and lower confidence, a phenomenon dubbed the "broken rung". According to the World Bank, nearly 50% of Indian women exit the workforce between early and mid-career, and only 27% of them return. This is not just a gender equity issue; it's a massive loss of skilled human capital in an economy that is aiming to become the talent engine of the world by India@100.

Returns offer a proven path forward. Structured re-entry programmes—with built-in mentorship, reskilling, and dedicated full-time conversion pathways—have been shown to significantly boost retention, loyalty, and innovation.

MENTORSHIP & SPONSORSHIP

In the conversation around gender equity in tech, we often focus on hiring targets, leadership quotas, or upskilling. But one of the most overlooked, yet most transformative, accelerators of women's success is intentional mentorship and active sponsorship. According to the World Bank, only one in five